

Aesop's Fables

Aesop

The Tortoise and the Hare

A Hare one day ridiculed the short feet and slow pace of the Tortoise, who replied, laughing: Though you be swift as the wind, I will beat you in a race. The Hare, believing her assertion to be simply impossible, assented to the proposal. The Tortoise, never for a moment stopping, plodded on and won. Slow but steady wins the race.

The Fox and the Grapes

A famished Fox saw some clusters of ripe black grapes hanging from a trellised vine. She resorted to all her tricks to get at them, but wearied herself in vain, for she could not reach them. At last she turned away, hiding her disappointment and saying: The Grapes are sour, and not ripe as I thought.

The Boy Who Cried Wolf

A shepherd-boy, who watched a flock of sheep near a village, brought out the villagers three or four times by crying out, Wolf! Wolf! and when his neighbors came to help him, laughed at them for their pains. The Wolf, however, did truly come at last. There is no believing a liar, even when he speaks the truth.

The Lion and the Mouse

A Lion was awakened from sleep by a Mouse running over his face. Rising up angrily, he caught him and was about to kill him, when the Mouse piteously entreated, saying: If you would only spare my life, I would be sure to repay your kindness. The Lion laughed and let him go. Little friends may prove great friends.

The North Wind and the Sun

The North Wind and the Sun disputed as to which was the most powerful, and agreed that he should be declared the victor who could first strip a wayfaring man of his clothes. Persuasion is better than force.

The Ant and the Grasshopper

The ants were spending a fine winter day drying grain collected in the summertime. A Grasshopper, perishing with famine, passed by and earnestly begged for a little food. The Ants inquired of him: Why did you not treasure up food during the summer? It is best to prepare for the days of necessity.